EVOLUTION OF THEATRE

From the Greeks to the Globe

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

Five thousand years of stage in one sweep: Athens, Rome, the medieval church, the commedia, the Elizabethan playhouse and the court stage.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- Athens
- Rome
- the medieval church
- commedia
- the Globe

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Athens

Theatre began in Athens as a festival of Dionysus: a chorus, a sacrifice, and a competition. The great theatre of Dionysus held perhaps fifteen thousand people, and the plays were performed in daylight, in masks, with a chorus in the orchestra and a wooden skene behind it.

What survived is a handful of plays by Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides and Aristophanes - a tiny fraction of what was produced - plus the physical evidence of the theatre and Aristotle's account of how it worked.

Rome

Roman theatre borrowed the Greek forms and changed the building: a raised stage with a scaenae frons, a semicircular auditorium on a flat foundation. Plautus and Terence wrote comedies of situation and character that became the model for European comedy; Seneca wrote tragedies of rhetoric and horror that shaped the Renaissance.

Rome also gave the stage its first professional companies, its first star actors and its first theatre riots.

The medieval stage

After the fall of the empire, theatre survived in the church, where the liturgy itself became dramatic: the quem quaeritis trope, the Easter sepulchre, the nativity dialogue. From there it moved out of doors into the mystery cycles, the miracle plays, the moralities and the saints' plays, performed on wagons, on pageants and in the round.

The medieval stage is the origin of the professional guild theatre, the crowd scene, the special effect and the comic devil.

The Renaissance and the Globe

The Renaissance rebuilt the stage on classical lines - the proscenium arch, perspective scenery and the picture-frame - in Italy, while England developed a different form. The Globe, built in 1599, was a polygonal open-air playhouse with a deep platform stage, a tiring house, a trap, a balcony and an audience standing in the yard.

Shakespeare wrote for that space, and its conventions - soliloquy, doubling, two hours' traffic - are written into the plays. A modern production that ignores the shape of the original stage is arguing with the text.

What the evidence actually is

The history of the theatre is built from three kinds of evidence: texts, buildings and pictures. For Greece we have a handful of plays, the remains of the theatre of Dionysus, and vase paintings. For Rome, plays, the ruins at Orange and Pompeii, and mosaics. For the medieval stage, play manuscripts, church records, and a few stage plans such as the Valenciennes drawing and the Castle of Perseverance plan.

Learn to say what is known and what is inferred. Nobody knows exactly how the Greek mask amplified the voice; nobody knows how the Globe's trapdoor was worked in every play. The honest history distinguishes the evidence from the reconstruction, and a good essay does the same.

Then use the reconstruction as a hypothesis. If the Globe's stage was deep and the audience stood in daylight, what

follows for the acting? If the Greek theatre held fifteen thousand people in the open air, what follows for the size of gesture? The building is an argument about performance, and reading it that way is the point of theatre history.

The repertoire as evidence

What survives is not what was popular. We have seven plays by Sophocles out of more than a hundred, and none of the hundreds of Roman mimes that drew the crowds. The canon is an accident of copying, and a history that treats it as a list of the best plays is confusing survival with merit.

Say so in your essays. "The surviving plays suggest" is a more honest sentence than "the Greeks believed", and it costs nothing except the habit of certainty.

Exercises

1. Draw and label the theatre of Dionysus and the Globe, and mark where the audience stood.
2. Explain how daylight performance shapes what a Greek or Elizabethan actor can do that a modern actor cannot.
3. Trace one stage convention (the soliloquy, the aside, the mask) from Athens to the Globe.

Where to read more

Roy C. Flickinger, The Greek Theater and Its Drama (1918)

A. W. Schlegel, Lectures on Dramatic Art and Literature (1809-11)

Oscar Brockett, History of the Theatre (any edition)

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